



United States
Attorney's Office
Central District of California



San Bernardino Church Pastor and Ex-Political Candidate Arrested for Alleged Wire Fraud Schemes Targeting Friends, Nonprofit



Friday, March 7, 2025

For Immediate Release

U.S. Attorney's Office, Central District of California

RIVERSIDE, California – A pastor at a San Bernardino church and one-time political candidate for the San Bernardino City Council has been arrested on an 11-count federal grand jury indictment alleging he committed several con jobs targeting long-time friends and a nonprofit corporation tied to another church, swindling them out of a total of more than \$230,000, the Justice Department announced today.

Terrance Owens Elliott, 60, a.k.a. "Tony Elliott," of Crestline, is charged with 11 counts of wire fraud.

Elliott was arrested Thursday and is scheduled to be arraigned this afternoon in United States District Court in Riverside.

The Family Trust

According to the indictment that a grand jury returned February 26, from October 2019 to February 2023, Elliott – representing himself as working in the San Bernardino city government and being involved with the San Bernardino Police Department – defrauded several long-time friends out of approximately \$150,263 by convincing one friend – identified in the indictment as "M.C" – to put her inheritance money into a trust for her own benefit. Elliott convinced this victim to allow him to establish and administer that trust, claiming that she would lose her Medicare and Social Security benefits if she directly received the inheritance.

Elliott prepared a trust agreement that appointed himself as a co-trustee. The trust provided that its money was to be used for the M.C.'s financial needs during her lifetime and permitted that her funeral

expenses were to be paid from the trust with any remaining property being passed to her children upon her death.

Elliott then opened a bank account in the trust's name listing only himself as a trustee and gave the bank a fraudulently modified copy of the trust agreement that purported that he had the sole power to make payments from the trust's bank account.

He then wrote checks and made online transfers to a church – identified in the indictment as “Church A” – that weren't permitted under the trust agreement. He also used the money from that trust's bank account to purchase postal money orders that were used to pay the church's rent. Elliott further used the account to pay for his personal expenses, including the repair of a Chevrolet truck, Nike sneakers, a piano, clothing, and an extended warranty for a motorcycle.

Elliott also obtained access to M.C.'s account at a different bank to make approximately \$27,164 in unauthorized transfers of some of her monthly Social Security payments to the church.

When the victim's family asked Elliott about the trust account or asked for bank statements, he lulled them into compliance by getting upset and telling them that everything was under control.

When M.C. died, Elliott tricked another victim – identified as “W.H.” – into paying approximately \$8,615 for the victim's funeral expenses, falsely claiming that he needed authorization from a judge before money in the trust bank account could be released.

Through this scheme, Elliott defrauded four victims – including M.C. and W.H. – out of at least approximately \$150,263.

The Corporation

In a separate scheme, from June 2021 to February 2023, Elliott advised victim W.H. on selling a house when renters occupied the property. After W.H. sold the house, Elliott called him and suggested the victim's corporation loan M.C.'s trust \$65,000, falsely claiming this would help the victim to avoid having to pay a capital gains tax from the house's sale.

Elliott prepared a loan contract between a corporation W.H. had set up and M.C.'s trust, which they signed. Elliott told W.H. that Elliott would transfer \$65,000 from the corporation to the trust account and that the trust would repay the loan with 10% annual interest. Elliott convinced the victim to give him several signed blank checks from the bank account of W.H.'s corporation.

Instead of honoring the contract, Elliott used one of the blank checks to make an unauthorized transfer to Church A – without W.H.'s knowledge or consent. Although Elliott ultimately transferred \$49,000 to the trust, he never repaid any part of the \$65,000 loan. Instead, he spent the bulk of the money on his own personal expenses.

Nonprofit Litigation

Finally, from September 2018 to June 2021, Elliott used his relationships with Church B and its board of directors to help manage the church's litigation expenses and other costs involving a different church – identified in the indictment as "Church B" and a nonprofit.

Elliott lied to the nonprofit and Church B's board of directors that the nonprofit owed money to W.H.'s corporation for services rendered related to litigation against them. He caused the nonprofit to issue approximately 32 checks to W.H.'s corporation, which Elliott later deposited in a corporation-related bank account that Elliott controlled.

Elliott did not use the money from the checks for the nonprofit's benefit and defrauded it out of approximately \$23,300.

In total, Elliott allegedly caused his victims approximately \$238,563 in losses.

An indictment is merely an allegation. All defendants are presumed innocent until proven guilty beyond a reasonable doubt in a court of law.

If convicted, Elliott would face a statutory maximum sentence of 20 years in federal prison for each count.

The FBI is investigating this matter. Based on evidence, investigators believe it is possible that Elliott has additional victims yet to be identified. If you have any information, please contact the FBI at (310) 477-6565 or tips.fbi.gov.

Assistant United States Attorney Benjamin J. Weir of the Riverside Branch Office is prosecuting this case.

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